

The Kulaks, small farmers in the Ukraine, were tortured so they would reveal where they had hidden food. The food was confiscated and the Kulaks starved to death. Millions of them.

Communists in China were no less brutal. Again, families with independent means were singled out as class enemies. They were arrested, tortured, starved, imprisoned, and murdered. No one knows exactly how many died in these campaigns, but it was in the millions. Probably more than in the Soviet Union or Germany.

What makes these campaigns especially interesting to us is that they targeted families. Totalitarian states, of which France's Committee of Public Safety was an early trial run, insist on the full cooperation and absolute obedience of their subject peoples. They cannot bear any competition from alternate or independent sources of fidelity. Neither religious groups nor ethnic groups, nor families are allowed to compete for power, influence or allegiance with the central political power. Anyone who opposes them, even if only by preaching or pamphleteering in opposition, is eliminated.

The last great example of this kind of state-level massacre was in Cambodia, where anyone who could read or write was labeled an "intellectual" and sent to labor in the country. Since no provisions had been made for these people's lodging or nourishment, millions died on forced marches, diseases, overwork, exposure, and starvation.

What we take from these examples, as well as from the logic of the situations themselves, is that the state is often the enemy of families. In addition, the bigger the state gets and the more absurd its pretensions and promises become, the more likely it is to want to wipe out families as a source of competition.

The other thing we take from this is that you are much better off with a well-organized, well-financed family. In all of the above cases, people with family money—preferably beyond the reach of the state—were better off than those without it.

In the end, well-run families are stronger and more reliable than the state.

Notes